

# Medications for Nurses

## Cardiovascular

| Name                | Use                                | Class                                                 | Key Fact                                                                                                       |
|---------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Amlodipine</b>   | Hypertension                       | Calcium channel blocker                               | Watch for peripheral edema                                                                                     |
| <b>Furosemide</b>   | Edema, hypertension                | Loop diuretic                                         | Monitor potassium, risk of ototoxicity at high doses                                                           |
| <b>Lisinopril</b>   | Hypertension, heart failure (HF)   | Angiotensin-converting enzyme (ACE) inhibitor (-pril) | Watch for cough, angioedema, hyperkalemia                                                                      |
| <b>Losartan</b>     | Hypertension, HF                   | Angiotensin II receptor blocker (ARB) (-sartan)       | Similar to ACE inhibitors but no dry cough                                                                     |
| <b>Metoprolol</b>   | Hypertension, HF, angina           | Beta-blocker (-olol/-ilol)                            | Hold if heart rate (HR) < 60 bpm                                                                               |
| <b>Adenosine</b>    | Supraventricular tachycardia (SVT) | Antidysrhythmic                                       | Causes brief asystole to reset rhythm – MONITOR WITH TELEMETRY!                                                |
| <b>Amiodarone</b>   | Ventricular dysrhythmias           | Antidysrhythmic                                       | Watch for pulmonary/liver toxicity                                                                             |
| <b>Atorvastatin</b> | High cholesterol                   | Statin                                                | Monitor liver panels; watch for muscle pain (rhabdomyolysis)                                                   |
| <b>Digoxin</b>      | HF, atrial fibrillation (Afib)     | Cardiac glycoside                                     | Monitor for toxicity (nausea, vomiting, vision changes); check apical pulse before giving (hold if HR < 60bpm) |

|                | Name          | Use                                                 | Class                            | Key Fact                                                                                             |
|----------------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cardiovascular | Nitroglycerin | Angina                                              | Nitrate                          | Causes headache, hypotension                                                                         |
|                | Clopidogrel   | Prevent clots                                       | Antiplatelet                     | Increases bleeding risk                                                                              |
|                | Enoxaparin    | Deep vein thrombosis (DVT), pulmonary embolism (PE) | Low molecular weight heparin     | No partial thromboplastin time (PTT) monitoring                                                      |
|                | Heparin       | DVT, PE                                             | Anticoagulant                    | Monitor PTT, the antidote is protamine sulfate                                                       |
|                | Warfarin      | DVT, PE                                             | Anticoagulant                    | Monitor international normalized ratio (INR), avoid vitamin K-rich foods                             |
| Diabetes       | Insulin       | Diabetes mellitus (DM): types 1 & 2                 | -                                | Lispro (rapid), regular (IV for DKA), NPH (intermediate), glargine (no peak); watch for hypoglycemia |
|                | Glipizide     | Type 2 DM                                           | Sulfonylurea                     | Risk of hypoglycemia, take with food, assess allergy to sulfa drugs                                  |
|                | Metformin     | Type 2 DM                                           | Biguanide                        | Does not cause hypoglycemia; risk of lactic acidosis                                                 |
| Respiratory    | Albuterol     | Acute asthma or COPD exacerbation                   | Short-acting beta-agonist (SABA) | Watch for tachycardia                                                                                |
|                | Fluticasone   | Allergies or asthma                                 | Corticosteroid                   | Rinse mouth after inhaler use                                                                        |

|                 | Name                   | Use                                 | Class                                  | Key Fact                                                                                         |
|-----------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Respiratory     | <b>Ipratropium</b>     | COPD or asthma                      | Anticholinergic                        | Commonly causes dry mouth                                                                        |
|                 | <b>Montelukast</b>     | Asthma or allergy prevention        | Leukotriene receptor antagonist        | Take it at night                                                                                 |
|                 | <b>Salmeterol</b>      | Long-term asthma or COPD management | Long-acting beta-agonist (LABA)        | Not for acute respiratory exacerbations                                                          |
| Pain Management | <b>Acetaminophen</b>   | Mild to severe pain, fever          | Analgesic, Antipyretic                 | Max 4g/day; antidote is acetylcysteine; caution with liver/kidney impairment                     |
|                 | <b>Ibuprofen</b>       | Mild to severe pain                 | Nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory (NSAID) | Take with food to prevent GI upset; caution with bleeding risk                                   |
|                 | <b>Morphine</b>        | Severe pain                         | Opioid                                 | Monitor level of consciousness (LOC); watch for respiratory depression; the antidote is naloxone |
|                 | <b>Oxycodone</b>       | Moderate to severe pain             | Opioid                                 | Monitor LOC; watch for respiratory depression; not intended for long-term use                    |
| GI              | <b>Docusate sodium</b> | Constipation                        | Stool softener                         | Promotes bowel movements                                                                         |
|                 | <b>Pantoprazole</b>    | GERD                                | Proton pump inhibitor (PPI) (-azole)   | Take before first meal of the day; long-term use increases risk of fractures                     |
| Neuro           | <b>Alprazolam</b>      | Anxiety and panic disorders         | Benzodiazepine                         | Risk of dependence, do not stop taking suddenly                                                  |

|                           | Name        | Use                                               | Class                                         | Key Fact                                                                                       |
|---------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Neuro/Psych/Mental Health | Donepezil   | Mild to moderate dementia (Alzheimer's disease)   | Acetylcholinesterase inhibitor                | Take at bedtime; may cause GI upset                                                            |
|                           | Fluoxetine  | Depression, anxiety disorder                      | Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor (SSRI) | Monitor for serotonin syndrome (fever, confusion); 4 - 6 weeks to take effect                  |
|                           | Gabapentin  | Seizure prophylaxis or neuropathic pain           | Anticonvulsant                                | Taper off slowly; avoid alcohol                                                                |
|                           | Haloperidol | Acute psychosis, schizophrenia                    | Neuroleptic (nonphenothiazine)                | Watch for extrapyramidal symptoms (EPS), QT prolongation, neuroleptic malignant syndrome (NMS) |
|                           | Lithium     | Bipolar disorder (mania), schizophrenia           | Mood stabilizer                               | Narrow therapeutic range (0.6 - 1.2), avoid dehydration                                        |
|                           | Olanzapine  | Schizophrenia, bipolar disorder, depression       | Atypical antipsychotic                        | Watch for weight gain, metabolic syndrome                                                      |
|                           | Memantine   | Moderate to severe dementia (Alzheimer's disease) | NMDA receptor antagonist                      | May cause dizziness or rash                                                                    |
|                           | Phenytoin   | Seizures                                          | Anticonvulsant (hydantoin)                    | Monitor therapeutic range (10-20 mcg/mL); watch for gingival hyperplasia                       |
|                           | Zolpidem    | Insomnia                                          | Sedative-hypnotic (nonbenzodiazepine)         | Meant for short-term use; avoid other CNS depressants                                          |

|                        | Name                    | Use                                                                                                                | Class                       | Key Fact                                                                           |
|------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Antibiotics/Antivirals | <b>Azithromycin</b>     | Upper and lower respiratory, sexually transmitted, and skin infections                                             | Macrolide                   | Can cause QT prolongation; take on an empty stomach                                |
|                        | <b>Ciprofloxacin</b>    | Respiratory, urinary, skin, eye, and ear infections                                                                | Fluoroquinolone             | Risk for tendon rupture; avoid in pediatrics                                       |
|                        | <b>Gentamicin</b>       | Serious infections included sepsis, MRSA, and endocarditis                                                         | Aminoglycoside              | Watch for ototoxicity and nephrotoxicity                                           |
|                        | <b>Metronidazole</b>    | Anaerobic bacterial infections, <i>Clostridioides difficile</i> infection, acne rosacea                            | Nitroimidazole              | NO alcohol; may cause disulfiram-like reaction                                     |
|                        | <b>Vancomycin</b>       | Serious infections like endocarditis, MRSA, <i>Clostridioides difficile</i> , and respiratory/skin/bone infections | Glycopeptide                | Monitor for vancomycin flushing syndrome (red man syndrome); monitor trough levels |
| OB                     | <b>Methylergonovine</b> | Prevention and treatment of postpartum hemorrhage                                                                  | Uterotonic                  | Avoid with hypertension                                                            |
|                        | <b>Oxytocin</b>         | Labor induction or prevention and treatment of postpartum bleeding                                                 | Uterotonic (oxytocic agent) | Monitor for uterine hyperstimulation, fetal intolerance                            |
| Other                  | <b>Levothyroxine</b>    | Hypothyroidism                                                                                                     | Thyroid hormone             | Take on an empty stomach in the morning                                            |

|       | Name               | Use                               | Class                      | Key Fact                                                                              |
|-------|--------------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Other | Epoetin alfa       | Anemia                            | Biologic response modifier | Stimulates RBCs; monitor hemoglobin; risk of hypertension                             |
|       | Potassium chloride | Hypokalemia                       | Electrolyte replacement    | NEVER push IV; dilute to avoid phlebitis; monitor potassium levels and cardiac rhythm |
|       | Methotrexate       | Rheumatoid Arthritis (RA), Cancer | Folic acid antagonist      | Avoid in pregnancy; monitor bone marrow suppression and liver function                |



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